happened to be in the city at that moment, disguised first as a Muslim horse trader then as a sayyid [divine]. Lieutenant Eldred Pottinger was the nephew of the spymaster of Bhuj, and Burnes's former boss, Sir Henry Pottinger. His presence in Herat was probably more than fortuitous, and provided a stream of much-needed information for the British during the siege. In British accounts, 'the Hero of Herat' (as Pottinger was dubbed in Maud Diver's jingoistic Victorian novel) is usually credited with steeling the resolve of the Heratis to defend their city and more or less keeping the Persians at bay single-handedly. This is not, however, a version of events which is supported by any of the many Persian or Afghan chronicles. Here the siege is seen as a titanic struggle between the two peoples, one Sunni, one Shia; and the fortitude of the Herati defenders, subject to the most horrific privations, was depicted as an epic of Afghan bravery and resistance. Indeed two of the most important Afghan historians living at the time devote almost as many pages to the siege of Herat as they do to the British invasion which followed it. Both were seen as equally formidable threats to the independence of Khurasan.

According to these Afghan sources, as soon as news arrived that the Persian army was heading towards Herat, Shah Kamran ordered grain and forage to be brought in, and the fruit trees in the gardens outside the walls to be cut down. Levies were summoned from the Sadozais' Uzbek and Hazara tribal allies, and the city's massive earthen walls were repaired and reinforced. So were those of the Ikhtiyar al-Din, the vast citadel of Herat that occupied an area that was equivalent to two-thirds of the city itself.[85] By 13 November, the advance guard of the Persian army had arrived outside the border fortress of Ghorian. The Herati chronicler Riyazi in the '*Ayn al-Waqayi* recorded how the Persians captured the mighty castle in less than twelve hours with the aid of their British-trained artillery: 'so many cannon were fired at the Qala'-i Ghorian that three of its sides completely collapsed'. In this way, wrote Fayz Mohammad, 'the touch-paper of war was lit and preparations were made in the army of Iran for a major assault on Herat'.

A few days later, the first divisions of the enormous 30,000-strong Persian army marched along the valley of the Hari Rud towards the walls of Herat, easily driving off the squadrons of cavalry sent out against them. 'A skirmish was fought and many men died,' wrote Fayz Mohammad, 'but when the vast numbers of the main Iranian army hove into view, the Heratis